Harriet Dart Reaches Her First WTA Singles Final

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A long wait ended in tears of joy.

British tennis player Harriet Dart said it 'means the world' to reach her first WTA Tour singles final, after beating Chinese **wildcard** Sun Xinran in three sets at the Guangzhou Open. Dart, the British number five, was playing only her second tour-level singles semi-final. She had previously reached the last four at the 2024 Transylvania Open, and she made her WTA Tour **debut** in Eastbourne in 2015.

'It's been a really long journey,' Dart said. 'I've wanted it so much, so badly sometimes too much. To finally be here means the world.' She said she found it tough, called the match a rollercoaster, and admitted she had been battling with herself as nerves and feelings grew. She was proud of the second set and of turning things around quickly.

The match swung back and forth. Dart trailed 3-0 in the first set, fought back to lead 5-4, then lost the opener after more **double faults** as she served for the set. Sun, the 16-year-old reigning US Open junior champion, took her chance. In the second set, Dart twice broke serve and was broken back at once, then twice served to stay in the match before winning the **tie-break** 7-1. In the deciding set, with Sun struggling and receiving a **medical timeout** for treatment on her left leg, Dart won every game.

Now Dart faces fourth **seed** Lilli Tagger in Sunday's final. Victory would return her to the top 100; she has already climbed 14 places to 101st in the live standings. Tagger, ranked 53rd, won her semi-final 6-2 6-0 in 53 minutes.

Word Treasure

wildcard -- A player given a special place in a tournament without qualifying in the usual way.

debut -- Someone's first appearance in an event or at a certain level.

tie-break -- A short deciding game played when players are level in a set.

medical timeout -- A pause in a match so an injured or struggling player can get treatment.

seed -- A highly ranked player given a protected position in a tournament draw.

double faults -- Serving mistakes where a player misses both serve attempts and loses the point.

Background you need

The WTA Tour is the main professional tennis circuit for women, where players compete in tournaments around the world and earn ranking points.

In a singles tournament, players must win match after match to move from the early rounds through the semi-final and into the final.

Harriet Dart had reached the last four of a tour event before, but she had never reached a tour-level singles final.

Beating Sun Xinran in the semi-final therefore gave Dart the breakthrough she had been chasing since her WTA Tour debut.

Break it down

LEAD: Harriet Dart reached her first WTA Tour singles final at the Guangzhou Open.
KEY EVENT: Dart beat Sun Xinran in three sets in the semi-final.
+- WHO: Dart, the British number five, against 16-year-old Sun Xinran
+- HOW IT SWUNG: Dart lost the first set, won the second-set tie-break 7-1, then won every game in the deciding set
EVIDENCE: Dart said reaching the final 'means the world' after a really long journey.
OPEN QUESTION: Dart now faces fourth seed Lilli Tagger, and victory would return her to the top 100.

Why it matters

Dart's breakthrough shows how years of persistence can pay off even when progress feels slow. It also lifts her live standing to 101st, close to a return to the top 100.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Harriet Dart beat in the semi-final?

- (A) The British number five
- (B) A player from the 2024 Transylvania Open
- (C) Lilli Tagger
- (D) Sun Xinran

2. At which tournament did Dart reach her first WTA Tour singles final?

- (A) The Transylvania Open
- (B) The Guangzhou Open
- (C) Eastbourne
- (D) The US Open

3. What was the score in the second-set tie-break?

- (A) 5-4 to Sun
- (B) 7-1 to Dart
- (C) 7-1 to Sun
- (D) 6-2 to Dart

4. Who will Dart face in Sunday's final?

- (A) The reigning US Open junior champion
- (B) A Chinese wildcard
- (C) Sun Xinran
- (D) Lilli Tagger

5. What would victory in the final return Dart to?

- (A) The top 100
- (B) The last four
- (C) The British number five spot
- (D) Her first semi-final

6. What happened in the deciding set?

- (A) Dart won every game while Sun struggled and received a medical timeout for her left leg
- (B) Sun won after a tie-break
- (C) Dart lost every game
- (D) The match was stopped because of nerves

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Harriet Dart: Dart said reaching the final means the world, called the match a rollercoaster, admitted battling nerves, and said she was proud of turning things around quickly.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):